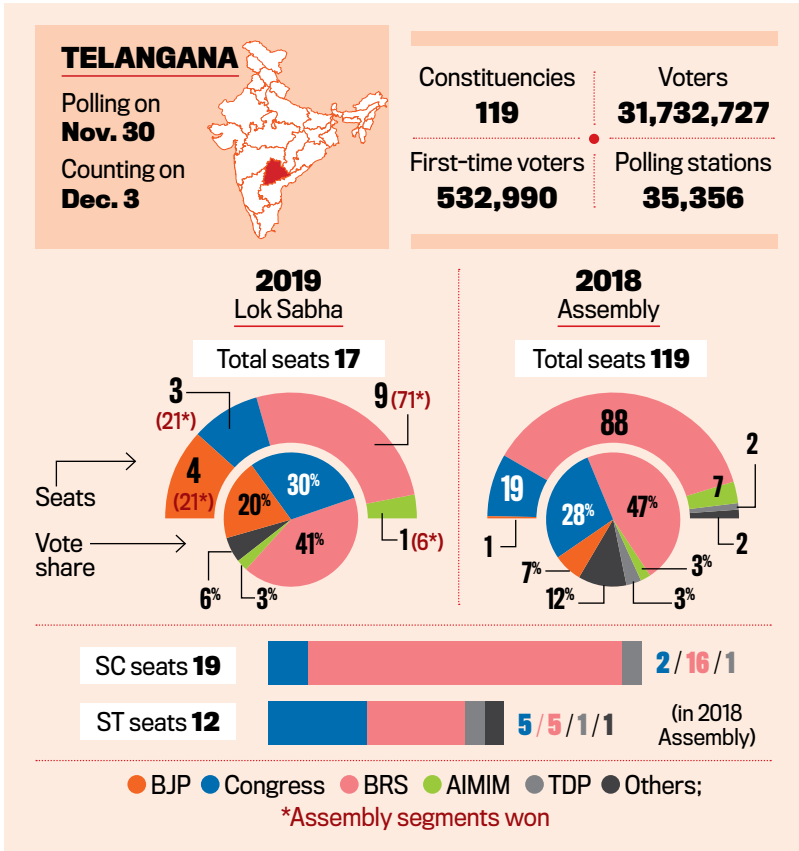


ing. "The CM is bankrolling his campaign with the proceeds from selling thousands of acres of land, and Rs 15 crore has already reached each constituency."

In 2014, though Sonia Gandhi delivered on the promise of creating a separate Telangana, KCR got the support of the voters who believed the state's creation owed much to his efforts. In 2018, the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) was seen as a party that had done nothing wrong for the people for them to punish it and the Congress-TDP alliance, perceived as anti-Telangana, inadvertently aided KCR's cause. The TRS secured a mammoth 88 out of 119 seats, an incredible three-quarter majority and a jump of 25 from the half-way mark region of 63 it got in 2014. However, this time around, the spectre of anti-incumbency overshadows the fight for Telangana's interests. Recognising this, the BRS streamed old footage of KCR's hunger strike for statehood within an hour of the poll schedule announcement on October 9.

"KCR will be a man with both confidence and anxiety now that the election schedule has been announced. The confidence is a façade to cover the serious problems on the ground," says Harathi Vageesan, who teaches political science at NALSAR University, Hyderabad. "The election is going to be a test of the overall performance of the BRS, though it will bank on welfare measures, providing water and, to some extent, on creating ambitious but patchy healthcare infrastructure."

One of KCR's significant challenges is his government's inability to impress the youth, a substantial portion of the electorate, by offering employment opportunities. Additionally, KCR's reputation for political savvy has taken a beating. Even a year after transforming his party from the TRS to the BRS, he has made limited progress in pursuing his national ambitions. Beyond Telangana, BRS holds only a symbolic presence in neighbouring Maharashtra. "Now, the BRS seems to have no new idea to take to the people. It has to rely on repackaging its performance whatever may be its texture and essence," says Vageesan.

Analysts say the electoral battle is expected to be primarily between the BRS and Congress. However, the Grand Old Party's ability to edge out the ruling party will hinge on how it meets the specific challenges in each constituency. For now, it is focusing on local issues and the 'failure' of incumbent MLAs to keep their promises as well as the allegations of corruption against the BRS first family. KCR is bracing for constituency-level micromanagement depending on whom the Congress fields against the BRS.

Due to an unusually high demand for tickets, the Congress has postponed its candidate announcement till October 24. State Congress president A. Revanth Reddy says, "The six guarantees announced by Sonia Gandhi for the people of Telangana are our candidates and we are going into the poll campaign with them. The candidates' list will come at the right time as per our strategy." On September 17, Sonia announced six guarantees, a repeat of the party's strategy in Karnataka, which included provisions such as a monthly allowance for women and affordable cooking gas cylinders. These assurances were met with criticism from both the BRS and BJP.

Analysts also say despite the perception of an unspoken understanding between the BRS and the BJP, the latter has the potential to damage the BRS's prospects in at least 10 constituencies as it tries to make strategic inroads for the Lok Sabha polls next year. In 2019, the BJP won four of the 17 seats and is nurturing hopes of increasing its tally in 2024 even as it strives to strengthen its current strength of three MLAs. However, it is unable to find strong candidates and is, therefore, banking on the Modi magic and its investments and projects, including the recent decision to set up a Turmeric Board.

As is his wont, KCR will seek to run down his rivals while invoking the sentiments and sacrifices associated with statehood. However, the anti-incumbency against at least half of the BRS MLAs, coupled with allegations of corruption and the perception of perpetuating dynastic rule, could greatly weigh against what his party portrays as a potential historic triumph in South India. ■